

Mining Strategy

China Commodity Trade Jun-26: Resilient, but Divergent outlook

Equities

Global

Basic Materials

China June-26 commodities maintain momentum

China's June preliminary trade data continues to show resilient physical flows, but increasingly mixed fundamental signals. Bulk commodities remain weighed down by soft demand and rising supply, while copper and aluminium continue to benefit from structural demand and tighter supply conditions, albeit aluminium fundamentals are seen easing from here.

Highlights: Iron Ore and Industrial Metals maintain strong momentum

Iron Ore imports rose to 112.6Mt (+6% y/y, +15% m/m, +6% YTD), reversing a weak May and returning to late-2025 levels (~110-120Mt/mth). Annualised imports are running at ~1.35 Btpa, consistent with strong 2026 supply from Australia, Brazil, early Simandou ramp-up & Fe grade degradation (eg: BHP, RIO and FMG reducing Fe spec). However, the signals on demand remain muted. China net steel exports are -5% YTD, iron ore port stocks elevated at ~158.5Mt (but below all-time highs ~167Mt in March), and export shipments have continued to lift. This divergence suggests imports are being driven by plentiful supply and inventory dynamics and perhaps less so end demand. Even with spot at ~US\$98/t and inside [cost support \(95th percentile ~US\\$99-101/t\)](#), we anticipate iron ore to drift lower towards [~US\\$92/t through 2026/27/28](#) as supply growth (eg: Simandou) outpaces demand.

Copper concentrate imports were broadly flat (2.33Mt; -1% YTD), reflecting tight upstream supply (low TC/RCs) amidst continued competition for feedstock. Refined imports rose 5% m/m but remain -5% YTD. The shortage of concentrate (eg: Grasberg, Cobre Panama outages and generally muted Chile and Peru production trends) may see increased imports of refined to meet demand, which [remains structurally strong \(electrification/AIDC\)](#). The result of strong underlying demand and constrained supply is deficits likely over the next 1-3 years, anchoring prices around ~US\$6-6.50/lb.

Aluminium exports rose to 0.71Mt (+45% y/y, +12% m/m, +16% YTD) and running at ~8.5Mt annualised with strength reflecting robust demand ex-China given 2.5-3Mt of downstream supply offline (Middle East, Mozal). This is consistent with our near-term view, with the market in deficit in 2026 amid lingering Middle East disruptions. However, while prices remain supported by cost inflation, low visible inventories and the [copper-aluminium substitution dynamic](#) (Cu:Al ratio >4x), we see [tightness easing over the next 6-12 months](#) as ~3Mt of Middle East supply restarts and Indonesian capacity accelerates (driving ~5%/3% global supply growth in 2026/27 vs ~2.5-3% demand). Therefore, recent Chinese metal export strength likely reverses as markets normalise. We expect the market to rebalance into 2027-28 rather than move into surplus, with prices ultimately rebasing above the cost curve, albeit with less upside than implied by current tight conditions.

Steel exports reached 10.3Mt in June (+7% y/y, flat m/m), with net exports at 9.9Mt (+7% y/y, -5% YTD, 118Mtpa annualised). Volumes have recovered materially from the Jan/Feb trough (~7.4Mt/month) following export licence tightening, but remain below late-2025 peaks (~10.5-11.3Mt/month). Export arbitrage remains open and mills remain profitable, limiting downside to production despite weaker domestic demand. Imports remain negligible (~0.4Mt; -11% YTD), reinforcing China's structural export surplus.

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Coal imports rose to 42.8Mt (+30% y/y, +29% m/m; +2% YTD), rebounding sharply from a weak April/May period. Increased coal import demand likely reflects a combination of i) domestic supply disruptions (Shanxi mine explosion), ii) strong seasonal power demand growth, iii) focus on thermal coal strategic stockpiles, & iv) possible gas to coal switching.

Rare Earths exports declined to 5.1kt in June (-34% y/y, -7% m/m; -6% YTD), extending the recent downtrend after a strong 2025. The weakness is largely policy-driven rather than demand-led, with tighter controls on the production and export of strategic materials weighing on outbound volumes. This reinforces the view that rare earth trade flows are increasingly decoupled from market fundamentals, with geopolitics and export regulation the dominant drivers.

Equities: Copper constrained, Iron ore resilient, Aluminium easing

In Australian Miners, we see balanced risk/reward on **BHP & RIO** and are Neutral each, with BHP preferred. Resilient Chinese iron ore imports, as well as cost curve support; and lithium volume & price leverage, also has us Buy rated **MIN**. In Copper, we are Buy rated **CSC** and Neutral rated **SFR**.

CHINA KEY TRADE FLOWS

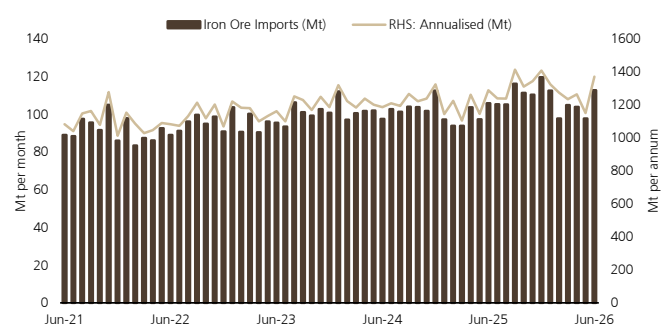
Figure 1: China Key Trade Flows

		Jul-24	Aug-24	Sep-24	Oct-24	Nov-24	Dec-24	Jan-25	Feb-25	Mar-25	Apr-25	May-25	Jun-25	Jul-25	Aug-25	Sep-25	Oct-25	Nov-25	Dec-25	Jan-26	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26	%y/y	%m/m	%YTD
Iron Ore Imports	Mt	102.6	101.3	103.9	103.7	101.7	112.4	97.2	93.8	93.8	103.6	97.2	105.8	105.2	105.0	116.1	111.2	110.3	119.5	112.4	97.6	104.7	103.8	97.7	112.6	6%	15%	6%
Annualised Iron Ore Imports	Mt	1232	1215	1247	1244	1220	1349	1166	1126	1125	1244	1167	1269	1262	1261	1393	1334	1324	1434	1349	1172	1257	1246	1172	1351			
Steel Exports	Mt	7.8	9.4	10.1	11.2	9.3	9.7	8.9	8.0	10.5	10.5	10.6	9.7	9.8	9.5	10.5	9.8	10.0	11.3	7.8	7.8	9.1	9.5	10.3	10.3	7%	0%	-6%
Annualised Steel Exports	Mt	93	113	121	134	111	117	107	96	125	126	127	116	118	114	126	117	120	136	93	94	110	114	124	124			
Steel Imports	Mt	0.5	0.5	0.6	0.5	0.5	0.6	0.5	0.6	0.5	0.5	0.5	0.5	0.4	0.5	0.6	0.5	0.5	0.5	0.5	0.4	0.5	0.5	0.5	0.4	-6%	-1%	-11%
Annualised Steel Imports	Mt	6.1	6.1	6.6	6.4	5.7	7.5	6.0	6.7	6.0	6.2	5.9	5.7	5.2	6.0	6.7	6.1	6.0	6.2	5.5	4.4	6.1	5.5	5.4	5.4			
Net Steel Exports	Mt	7.3	8.9	9.5	10.6	8.8	9.1	8.4	7.5	10.0	9.9	10.1	9.2	9.4	9.0	9.9	9.3	9.5	10.8	7.3	7.5	8.6	9.0	9.9	9.9	7%	0%	-5%
Annualised Net Steel Exports	Mt	87	107	115	127	106	109	101	90	119	119	121	110	113	108	119	111	114	129	87	90	103	108	119	118			
Coal Imports	Mt	46.2	45.8	47.6	46.2	55.0	52.3	41.8	34.3	38.7	37.8	36.0	33.0	35.7	42.6	45.9	41.7	44.1	58.6	46.3	30.9	39.1	33.1	33.3	42.8	30%	29%	2%
Annualised Coal Imports	Mt	555	550	571	554	660	628	501	412	465	454	432	396	428	512	551	501	529	703	555	371	469	397	399	513			
Copper Concentrate Imports	Mt	2.16	2.57	2.43	2.31	2.23	2.52	2.53	2.17	2.39	2.94	2.37	2.33	2.58	2.74	2.58	2.45	2.52	2.70	2.62	2.31	2.63	2.35	2.37	2.33	0%	-1%	-1%
Annualised Copper Concentrate Imports	Mt	25.9	30.8	29.2	27.7	26.8	30.2	30.4	26.1	28.7	35.3	28.4	28.0	30.9	32.9	31.0	29.4	30.3	32.4	31.4	27.8	31.5	28.2	28.4	28.0			
Copper Metal Imports	Kt	437	414	479	506	528	559	420	414	469	439	423	464	484	423	483	437	424	440	380	320	415	455	443	478	3%	8%	-5%
Annualised Copper Metal Imports	Kt	5244	4968	5747	6073	6336	6708	5040	4968	5628	5268	5076	5572	5804	5076	5791	5249	5088	5280	4560	3840	4980	5460	5314	5739			
Aluminium Exports	Mt	0.59	0.59	0.56	0.58	0.67	0.51	0.49	0.37	0.51	0.52	0.55	0.49	0.54	0.53	0.52	0.50	0.57	0.54	0.54	0.43	0.49	0.59	0.64	0.71	45%	12%	16%
Annualised Aluminium Exports	Mt	7.03	7.13	6.74	6.92	8.03	6.07	5.88	4.45	6.07	6.19	6.59	5.87	6.49	6.41	6.24	6.04	6.83	6.49	6.48	5.17	5.82	7.13	7.63	8.53			
Crude Oil Imports	Mt	42.3	49.1	45.5	44.7	48.5	47.7	41.2	42.6	51.1	48.2	46.4	49.9	47.2	49.5	46.9	48.0	50.9	55.9	48.9	48.0	49.9	38.5	33.1	29.2	-41%	-12%	-11%
Annualised Crude Oil Imports	Mt	508	589	546	536	582	572	494	511	614	578	557	599	567	594	563	576	610	670	587	577	599	461	397	351			
Rare Earths Exports	Kmt	4.9	4.7	4.2	4.8	4.4	3.3	5.3	3.2	5.7	4.8	5.9	7.7	6.0	5.8	4.0	4.3	5.5	4.4	6.1	4.4	4.1	5.3	5.5	5.1	-34%	-7%	-6%
Annualised Rare Earths Exports	Kmt	59	57	50	57	53	40	63	39	68	57	70	93	72	69	48	52	66	53	73	53	49	64	66	61			

Source: Haver, Bloomberg, UBS

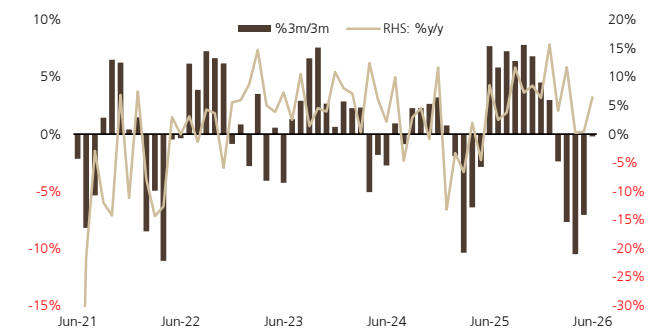
CHINA TRADE SIGNALS

Figure 2: Iron Ore Imports - mthly and ann'd



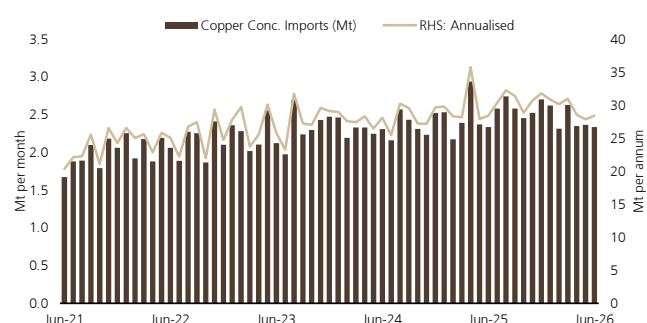
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 3: Iron Ore Imports - %3m/3m and %y/y



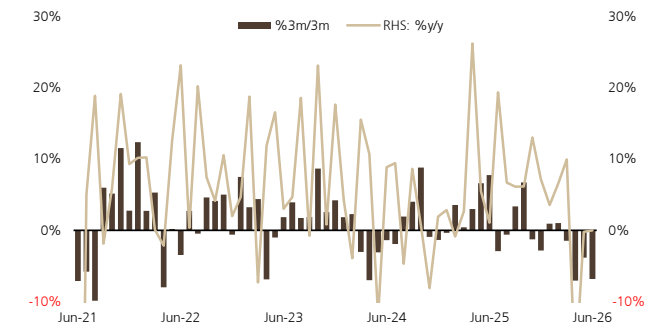
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 4: Copper Concentrate Imports - mthly and ann'd



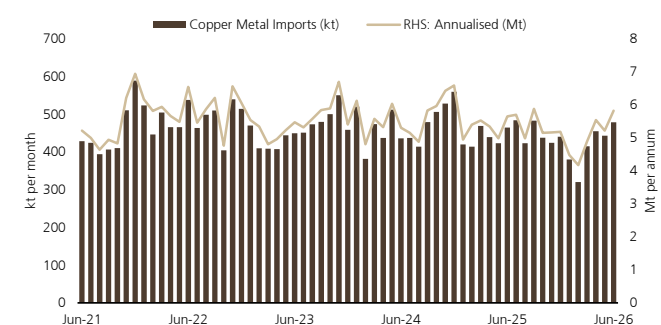
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 5: Copper Concentrate Imports - %3m/3m and %y/y



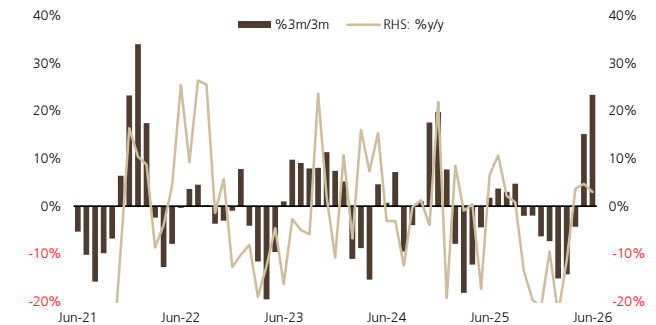
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 6: Copper Metal Imports - mthly and ann'd



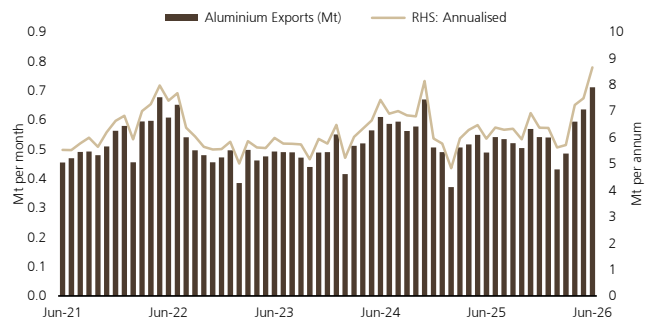
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 7: Copper Metal Imports - %3m/3m and %y/y



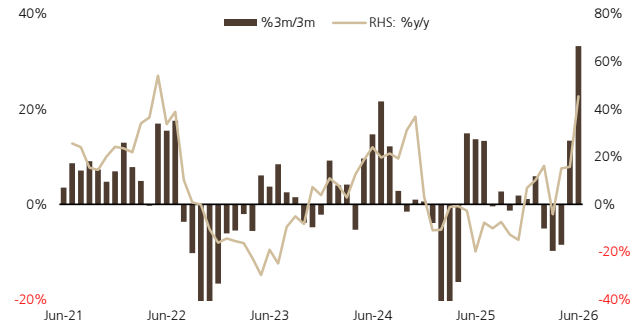
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 8: Aluminium Exports - mthly and ann'd



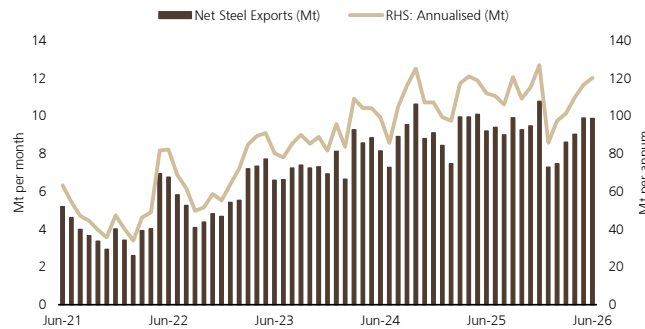
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 9: Aluminium Exports - %3m/3m and %y/y



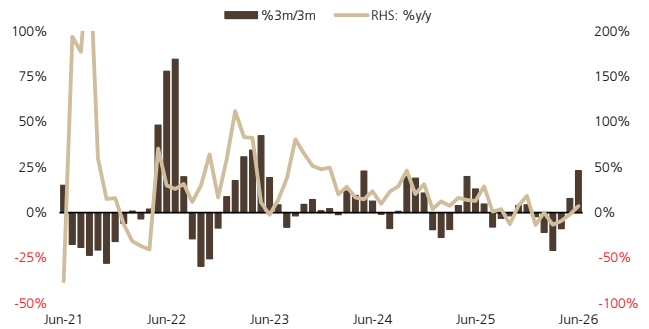
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 10: Net Steel Exports - mthly & ann'd



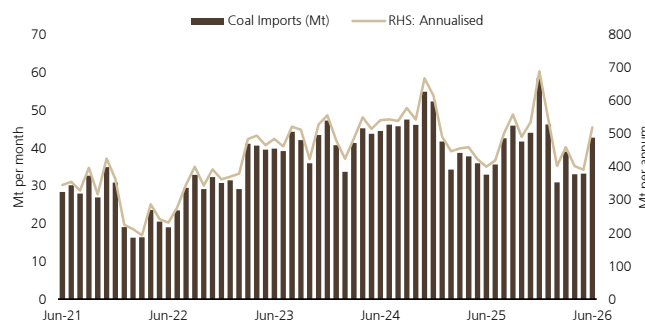
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 11: Net Steel Exports - %3m/3m and %y/y



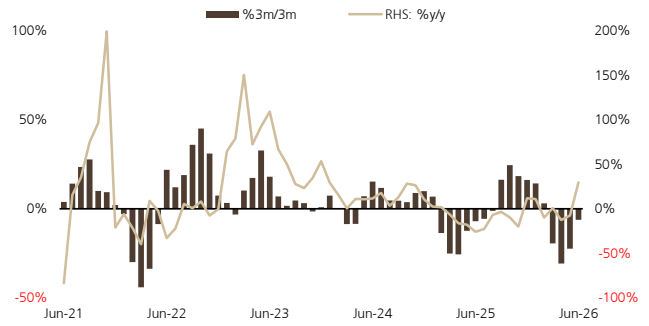
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 12: Coal Imports - mthly and ann'd



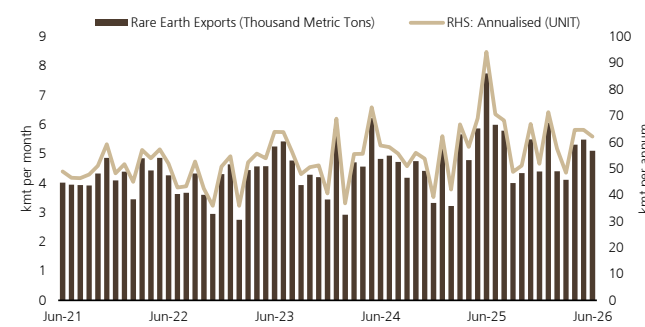
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 13: Coal Imports - %3m/3m and %y/y



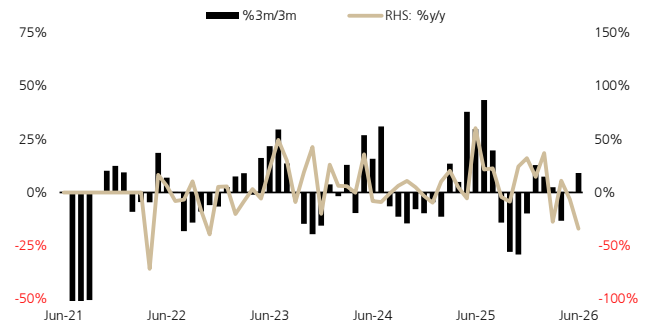
Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 14: Rare Earth Exports - mthly and ann'd



Source: Haver/UBS

Figure 15: Rare Earth Exports - %3m/3m and %y/y



Source: Haver/UBS

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Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 30 June 2026.

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2:Percentage of companies within the 12-month rating category for which investment banking (IB) services were provided within the past 12 months.

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Company Disclosures

Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
BHP ^{2,14,4,16,28,7,6c}	BHP.AX	Neutral	A\$58.71	14 Jul 2026
BHP Group ^{2,14,4,16,28,7,6c}	BHPB.L	Neutral	3,055p	13 Jul 2026
Capstone Copper ²⁸	CSC.AX	Buy	A\$13.19	14 Jul 2026
Mineral Resources ²⁸	MIN.AX	Buy	A\$58.90	14 Jul 2026
Rio Tinto ^{5,28,6c}	RIO.AX	Neutral	A\$163.61	14 Jul 2026
Rio Tinto Plc ^{12,14,16,28,7,6a,6b}	RIO.L	Neutral	6,733p	13 Jul 2026
Sandfire Resources ²⁸	SFR.AX	Neutral	A\$18.85	14 Jul 2026

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon. All prices as of local market close. Ratings in this table are the most current published ratings prior to this report. They may be more recent than the stock pricing date.

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